

EUROPEAN FOLK MAGIC

the common magical tradition

From the 5th century onward, Christianity spread across Europe, and pagan religions were driven into the shadows. The early Church associated magic with paganism and demons, yet a common tradition of magic survived, and even thrived, in Europe throughout the medieval period. This tradition was made up of a variety of practices, often with complex relationships to Christianity, that were carried out by a wide range of people, including physicians and even churchmen. Unlike the elite magic studied by scholars, common magical practices were also accessible to ordinary folk, for whom they offered solutions to everyday troubles, such as relationship problems, sickness, and crop failure.

Magic of words

Throughout the medieval period, magic words, spells, and incantations were called upon to do anything from ensuring a safe journey to bringing sickness or death upon a person. Mostly, words were thought to have more power when they were spoken out loud rather than written down. People might have worn amulets with magic words written on them, but primarily as a reminder of the words of power that were to be spoken.

Typically, spells were in meter and rhyme—making them easy to chant, like poetry. Many Anglo-Saxon charms were recorded in medical books, because they were considered a legitimate way of dealing with an ailment. But people might as readily have been given a charm to prevent theft or crop failure as to stop a nosebleed. One famous Anglo-Saxon charm, the *Wið færstice*, was used to stop

Mysterious runes



▲ Runic protection

The Bramham Moor Ring was found in Yorkshire and dates from the 9th century. No one has been able to decipher the runes inscribed on it, but they are thought to be magical.

► Extracting the swallow stone

This illustration from the *Anatomie of Melancholy* by Robert Burton shows someone removing a chelidonium (a stone inside a swallow, believed to have magical properties). The stone was wrapped in linen cloth and tied around the neck to cure fever or ward off evil.

